Johannes le Roux. ENTREPRENEUR COACH

Claude for *entrepreneurs.*

The remote version. Your own time, your own laptop, one real thing at the end of it.

Inus Smuts

Creative Director · Platō Coffee Group

WHAT YOU'RE BRINGING

A Shopify site for a new brand — one of the group's, not Platō itself. The design and the build, not the product copy.

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Before you start

Twenty minutes of setup. Do it the night before rather than at the top of the session — the one thing that reliably ruins a solo run is spending the first hour on an account problem.

1. A PAID CLAUDE PLAN

About R400 a month, billed by Anthropic. Then install the **desktop app**, not just the browser — the file handling is better and you'll be moving files. If your card declines it's almost always your bank blocking the international payment; enable that in your banking app and try again.

2. ADD THE WORKSHOP SKILL

Download it, and **don't unzip it**:

https://github.com/getluckyjo/claudeworkshop/raw/HEAD/dist/entrepreneurcoach.zip

In Claude: click your name bottom-left → Settings → Customize → Skills → upload the zip. You'll know it worked when **Entrepreneur Coach** appears in your list. Then open a *new* chat and type *help me get set up* — skills don't load into a conversation that was already running.

3. HAVE YOUR MATERIAL TO HAND

- Access to the Shopify store, and a theme you're allowed to duplicate
- A GitHub account — free, and use a personal username rather than a company one; you'll launch more than one brand
- The brand: logo, fonts, colours, and whatever art direction exists even if it's a moodboard
- Three sites you'd be pleased to have made, and one you can't stand. The one you hate is worth more than the three you like
- Which theme the store is on. Dawn and Horizon behave differently and it changes what to ask for

> **ONE RULE**
>
> You won't be asked to write code, open a terminal, or install anything beyond the app. If a step ever seems to need it, that means the session has taken a wrong turn — not that you've missed something. Mail me.

What you walk out with

Four things, running on your own machine. Not notes about how you might do it later.

1 **A Project that knows the brand**
Its documents, its rules, its voice — in one place that outlives the chat.

2 **One real artefact**
A file you can use, off your own product list.

3 **A skill that repeats it**
So the next one costs a fraction of the first.

4 **One job running on a schedule**
The first thing that happens without you.

BRIEFING, NOT PROMPTING

The single biggest difference between people who find this underwhelming and people who don't. A prompt asks for a thing. A brief says what you're trying to achieve and hands over what's needed to do it.

1. **The job.** What you want done, and why it matters.
2. **The context.** The brand, the constraints, the deadline.
3. **The material.** The real file. Not a description of it.
4. **What good looks like.** How you'd know it was done properly.
5. **The format.** A spreadsheet, a page, a document, a file.

Working alone, the failure mode is politeness. In a room I'd tell you to reject a bad answer out loud and say exactly what's wrong with it. On your own it's tempting to quietly fix it yourself and move on — which teaches it nothing, and you pay for the same flaw again on the next one. Say what's wrong. It's faster.

Design it by asking

The products are the easy half and you know it. What you actually want is to change how the thing looks and works without waiting on a developer or fighting a theme editor that won't do the layout in your head. That is buildable, it needs no terminal, and by the end of this you should have changed something on a storefront yourself and watched it appear.

THREE JOBS WEARING ONE COAT

“Build a Shopify site” is three different jobs, and they have nothing in common. **The store setup** — plan, payments, domain, shipping zones, tax — is you in the admin, clicking. Nothing here changes that. **The products** are copy and a CSV, or a direct connection if someone sets up an Admin API token; either way it's an afternoon and you've said it's the easy part.

The third is the theme — layout, sections, how it looks and moves. That's the one worth your three hours, and it's the one people assume is off the table. It isn't.

WHAT REPEATS AFTERWARDS

A skill carrying the brand's design rules — spacing, type scale, how it writes headings, what it never does. Then every new section arrives already looking like the brand instead of needing to be argued into it.

WATCH FOR

Two things will cost you the afternoon. The first is editing in the theme editor while Claude is working on the same files — the sync runs both ways, so that's a real conflict. One or the other at a time. The second is the pull toward polish: you'll want to perfect the hero before the loop is even working. Get the loop working first, on something ugly. Ugly and live beats beautiful and theoretical, and you can make it beautiful in about four minutes once you can change it by asking.

The loop, and why there's no terminal in it

A Shopify theme is a folder of files. Shopify publishes a GitHub app that keeps a repository branch and a theme in sync — push to the branch and the theme updates; edit in the admin and it commits back. Put Claude on the repository and the whole build becomes: ask for a change, look at it, merge it, see it in the preview.

1 Set it up once

In Shopify: Online Store → Themes → duplicate the theme you're working from. Connect the GitHub branch to *that duplicate*, never the live one. Then go to claude.ai/code, sign in with the same Claude account, connect GitHub, and open the repository.

Twenty minutes, all of it clicking. The one thing to get right is which theme the branch points at — the integration syncs to whatever it's told, and pointing it at the live theme makes every merge a deployment to customers. Claude Code on the web needs Pro or Max, and it's a research preview, so treat it as very good rather than bulletproof.

2 Then ask for sections, not pages

A section with a proper schema block shows up in the theme editor with its own controls — heading, image, alignment, full-bleed or not, whatever you specify.

This is the part worth reading twice. Ask for *a homepage* and you get a fixed thing only Claude can change. Ask for *a section with settings* and you get a new control in your own editor that you design with afterwards, forever, without asking anyone. You're not commissioning pages. You're building yourself a control panel.

> One rule above all others: **work on a duplicate.** A storefront taking orders is production. Nothing you do in the next three hours should be able to touch what a customer sees, and with an unpublished theme it can't.

The five steps

Roughly three hours, or three sittings. Be honest with yourself about the finish line: what you want by the end is the loop working and one section you built and then adjusted yourself. That's the moment it clicks. A whole storefront is the week after, and it goes fast once the loop exists.

1 Give it the eye before the work

> “Here's the brand — logo, fonts, colours, the moodboard. Here are three sites I'd be proud of and one I can't stand. Tell me what you think the visual rules are, and where I'm contradicting myself.”

Do this before anything is built. The last clause is the valuable one — it's the closest thing to a second art director in the room, and it will find the contradiction you've been carrying since the pitch. Argue with it. Write down what you settle on.

2 Wire the loop up

> “Walk me through connecting a Shopify theme to GitHub and then to Claude Code, so I can change the theme by asking. I'm duplicating the theme first and I am not touching the live one.”

Twenty minutes of clicking, and the only step that matters is pointing the branch at the duplicate. Once this works, everything after it is conversation.

3 One section, built properly

> “Build me one section with a full schema block — settings for the heading, the image, the alignment and whether it runs full-bleed. Before you write any Liquid, tell me which theme objects and filters you're relying on and which theme architecture you're assuming.”

That second sentence is doing real work: Liquid is where it will invent a filter that doesn't exist, and asking it to state its assumptions first surfaces the wrong one while it's still cheap. Then merge it, open the theme editor, and move the controls around. That is the whole point of the day.

4 Now the storefront

> “Same rules, the rest of it: the homepage, the product page, the collection page. Sections with settings, not fixed layouts. Show me each one before you move on.”

Look at everything on a phone before you like it. Most coffee gets bought on a phone in a queue, and a layout that sings on your 27-inch monitor can be unusable at 390 pixels.

5 Make it repeat

> “Write the brand's design rules up as a skill — spacing, type scale, how headings are written, what this brand never does — so the next section arrives already right.”

Name it after the brand, not after Platō. You'll launch another one, and the rules should travel with the brand they belong to.

Before you finish

Most training evaporates inside a fortnight, and solo runs evaporate faster because nobody asks you about it on the Monday. This is the page that decides whether yours does.

THE BRAND'S VOICE, IN ONE SENTENCE I'D DEFEND IN A MEETING

WHAT I BUILT, AND WHERE IT LIVES

WHAT BROKE, OR CAME BACK WRONG — THE USEFUL LIST

THE ONE THING I'LL DO BY FRIDAY

THEN

You're doing this without me in the room, so one ask: when something doesn't work, write down what you asked and what came back before you work around it. That list is worth more to the next version of this than anything that went smoothly.

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